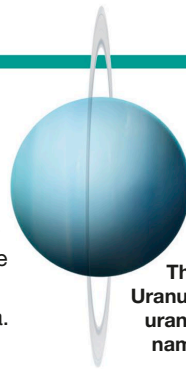


Naming elements

The two most common actinides, thorium and uranium, were discovered much earlier than the others and were named after Thor (the Norse god of thunder) and the planet Uranus, which was a recent discovery when uranium was identified. Most of the actinides were discovered in recent years and many of them were named after famous scientists – curium, after Marie Curie – or places, such as californium, after the American state of California.



The planet Uranus, which uranium was named after

Artificial elements

Of the actinides, only thorium and uranium are common enough to be refined from ores. Some other actinides do exist in nature but in tiny amounts.

Many actinides are created artificially in a particle accelerator, such as the linear accelerator shown here, which smashes atoms together to make bigger, heavier elements. They are also made in nuclear reactors as uranium atoms decay.

**Super Heavy Ion Linear Accelerator
in Lawrence Berkeley National
Laboratory, California, USA**

